

Tyson and the Kitten

COVER ART — Tyson, a big blocky soft-eyed pit bull with a goofy grin, and Miss, a tiny kitten, standing on top of his head like she owns him. Warm backyard light, fence line, big oak. Walker's silhouette far off, watching kindly.

A story about the name you're given and the friend who sees you

Tyson and the Kitten

For every good dog who got judged by the bark and not the heart.

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First edition.

ILLUSTRATION — Close-up, Tyson waving a paw at the reader, sweet-faced and hopeful.
Background animals flinch dramatically at his name.

Hi!
I'm Tyson.
Just Tyson.
The most misunderstood dog
on the whole wide block.

Go ahead.
Say it.
Tyson.

See?
You made the face.
Everybody does.

ILLUSTRATION — Cheerful street, BARKER BOULEVARD sign, Tyson trotting past fences,
tail wagging.

I live on
Barker Boulevard.
The grass glows.
The sprinklers sway.
The birds all sing.
The mail trucks play.

Most mornings smell like
sunshine and bacon.

I love it here.
Well... mostly.

ILLUSTRATION — Family portraits of gentle grinning pit bulls — one holds a flower, one naps under a kitten pile. The portraits contradict the gossip.

My pa was a Tyson.
His pa was too.
Big heads. Big hearts.
Tysons through and through.

Funny thing is...
not one of us
ever picked a fight.

Not one.

ILLUSTRATION — Fence-line animals whispering and judging. Tyson off to the side, hurt but trying to smile.

But the block didn't care.

"Tyson?" yipped a poodle.

"Sounds tough."

"Sounds scary."

"Sounds like trouble."

Nobody asked if I was kind.

Nobody even asked
my favorite treat.

Peanut butter.

Obviously.

ILLUSTRATION — Tyson alone on the sidewalk; the word TYSON echoes in bubbles, bigger and bigger, as animals point and whisper.

Maybe they wanted
to defame my name
because I wasn't the same.

Or maybe...
they just didn't want
to see me run farther
than they did.

I only knew this:

A name can echo.
Especially down a long fence line.

ILLUSTRATION — The Grumble Pack enters like a storm cloud — sour bulldog, hissing alley cat, droopy hound, crabby raccoon. Junkyard gate sign: GROWLER'S GRIPES.

Then came
the Grumble Pack,
slinking my way.

And as soon as the Grumblers
joined in the fray,
the rumors swirled
and twirled down the street.

"Tyson is trouble!
Just wait and see!"

ILLUSTRATION — Gag spread: rumor bubbles as sinking paper boats, Tyson in a tiny doghouse, a ten-foot leash from off-panel, a bowl labeled GOSSIP STEW.

Loose lips sink friendships,
and those lips let it rip.
They didn't like
the cut of my jib.

They had me in the doghouse,
stuck in dire straits,
tangled in gossip,
and blamed by my mates.

No one would touch me
with a ten-foot leash.

All because Grumblers
were stirring⁷ the street.

ILLUSTRATION — Gloomy chorus at the junkyard fence. Gray speech bubbles: Blame.
Defame. Complain. Again.

They growled and grumbled.
They groaned and complained.
They blamed and defamed,
then blamed me again.

With the unhappiest tone
on the whole grumpy block,
they said,

"With a name like Tyson,
how good can he be?"

ILLUSTRATION — Junkyard clubhouse interior. Menu board: Blame Chowder · Sour Kibble ·
Today's Special: Not My Fault. A tired old growler runs the counter.

At Growler's Gripes,
the Grumblers came
to whine and complain
and play the blame game.

They never grew.
They stayed the same.

Then blame someone else
for the mess that they made.

Which is convenient.
And also nonsense.

ILLUSTRATION — Ridiculous complaint circle. Trophies: First of the Worst · Most Miserable
· Champion Complainer. Tyson watches from the edge.

Their favorite game
was a miserable curse:

WHO'S GOT IT WORSE?

Who's first
at being the worst?

"My bone is too bony!"
"My yard has no shade!"
"My neighbor barks bubbles
of noise at my gate!"

ILLUSTRATION — The circle opens a space for Tyson. His goofy grin misread as a snarl by one dramatic chihuahua.

"Come sit," said the Grumblers.

"Come join our game.

You're a Tyson, dear Tyson.

You're surely the same."

I tried smiling.

"I'm friendly. See?"

They winked.

"Classic Tyson.

Dark irony."

ILLUSTRATION — Grumblers swirl around Tyson in gray-blue fog; their words become cartoonish chains and fences — not frightening.

They circled like smoke.
They crowded like fog.
They croaked like a cranky
old junkyard dog.

"Don't dream too big."

"Don't run too far."

"Stay where you are."

"You are what you are."

ILLUSTRATION — Tyson's ears droop. Dark thought-clouds circle his head, labeled Fail · Fall · Can't · Same.

Soon I felt groggy.
I grumbled. I groaned.
I started to hear
their unhappy tone.

What if I fail?
What if I fall?
What if a Tyson
can't change at all?

Their words wore smiles,
but they worked like hooks.
That's how bad advice
sometimes looks.

ILLUSTRATION — Tyson alone in the empty yard at dusk, small under a huge sky. A tiny toy ship's wheel waits in the sandbox — the choice.

I felt lost and low,
off the deep end,
out of my depth,
with no fair-weather friend.

Would I sink or swim?
Would I stay overwhelmed?

Or could I take hold
of my own little helm?

ILLUSTRATION — Miss struts in under the fence flap, tail high, walks straight between Tyson's front paws. The Grumblers are three times her size. She does not care.

Then the flap on the fence
went *flip* and *flick*—

and in marched Miss,
my best friend, the kitten.

All four pounds of her.

"Tyson," she said,
"I'm caught in their song too.
But I never sing it.
And neither should you."

ILLUSTRATION — Miss perched on Tyson's head like a tiny life coach. A water bowl beside them glows warm and full.

Miss curled up close.

"Let's be clear.

Not every loud mouth
deserves your ear.

Friends lift you up.

They fill your cup.

If they drag you down,
don't drink that stuff."

ILLUSTRATION — Miss points her tail at squirrels chanting YEAH-YEAH! at a wobbling branch — safely far from the danger they cheer for.

"If it dims you, ditch it.
If it shrinks you, run.
If they cheer when you're falling,
that friendship is done.

Some dogs want the show.
Some dogs want the fall.
The squirrels yell 'Yeah-yeah!'
but don't care at all."

Purrrrr.

ILLUSTRATION — Miss in a perfect purring loaf, eyes half closed, warm glow around her.
Tyson leans in, curious.

"That sounds wise, Miss.
But what do I do?"

Miss tucked her paws
and started to purr.
The whole loud world
went soft and blurred.

"This is my quiet place.
I take it everywhere.
When the block gets barky,
I go inward — right here."

ILLUSTRATION — Comedy spread: Tyson attempting to loaf like a kitten and failing spectacularly — legs everywhere, tongue out. Miss amused but kind.

I tried purring.

"Purr!" I said.

Nothing.

No rumble.

Just slobber instead.

I squeezed. I squinted.

I wiggled my tail.

But being a pit bull
is terrible training
for being a cat.

ILLUSTRATION — Both in the grass watching thought-birds labeled Can't · Fail · Same fly overhead — passing by without landing.

Miss opened one eye.
"You're not built like me.
You don't need a purr
to get quiet and see.

Breathe in the stillness.
Let thought-birds fly by.
A thought can pass over
without being true."

ILLUSTRATION — Walker arrives — a big old dog, calm as moonlight, muzzle gone silver.
Grass leans toward him as though listening. No background gags; this moment belongs to
Walker.

And that's when the yard
went strangely still.

The squirrels stopped chattering.
Even the wind
sat down to listen.

Through the gate came Walker,
old and gray,
a dog with a slow walk
and a wise way.

ILLUSTRATION — Walker and Tyson nose to nose at the fence. TYSON floats in a bubble between them; Walker looks past it, down the open road.

"Tyson," he rumbled,
"the obstacle's the way.
The thing that trips you
can teach you today."

I sighed.
"My name is the trouble.
That's plain as can be.
They hear 'Tyson'
and decide about me."

ILLUSTRATION — Tyson with the toy ship's wheel under one paw. Stormy rumor-clouds overhead; Walker's nose points toward a break in the sky.

Walker smiled softly.

"Names may start stories.

Choices steer dogs.

Their words are the weather.

Your will is the wheel.

Stay steady, young Tyson.

Keep an even keel."

ILLUSTRATION — Tyson running full-speed into the wind, ears flying, joyful — the wind carrying him forward instead of pushing him back. Walker's words glow around him.

"Why fight the current
when you can ride the wave?
Lean right in, Tyson.
Be gentle. Be brave.

The harder the wind,
the stronger you run."

Then he said the words
that changed everything:

"Your choices shape your fate.
Not your name."

ILLUSTRATION — Chains made of the letters T-Y-S-O-N dissolve into dandelion fluff and float away.

The words hit me
like a bright tidal wave.

Not loud. Not fancy.
But steady and brave.

*Maybe my name
isn't chains after all.*

*Maybe I choose
if I rise or I fall.*

ILLUSTRATION — Porch light. Three proud scratch-marks in the dirt by Tyson's bowl. Miss asleep against his side; Walker's silhouette in the next yard, keeping watch.

That night I scratched
three marks by my bowl —
three things that were good,
three things that were whole.

One: I have Miss,
who tells me what's true.

Two: I have Walker.

Three: **I can choose.**

ILLUSTRATION — Small vignettes: waking, stretching, sharing his bone, walking tall past the fence line, breathing slow. A single raindrop rippling outward.

Each morning I practiced
one brave little thought.
Each day I remembered
the lesson I'd caught.

Small steps. Same path.
Every day.

A little each day
helps you seize the day.

Just like...
a mighty wave begins
with a single drop.

ILLUSTRATION — Grumblers arrive smug with the old WHO'S GOT IT WORSE? sign; Tyson calmly flips over a new one: GOOD, BETTER, BEST. A squirrel drops his acorn.

The Grumble Pack came back
with their sour old test.

"Come play our game!
Who's Got It Worse?"

I smiled.
"No, thank you.
I've got a better game."

They blinked.

"Good. Better. Best."

ILLUSTRATION — Tyson explaining the rules while the Grumblers look horrified — like he suggested a bath before breakfast.

"The rules are simple.
Say something good
and let the game begin.

The next one says better.
The next one says best.
We count up our blessings
and outshine the rest."

The Grumblers stared.

Gratitude?
In public?
How deeply unfair.

ILLUSTRATION — The gratitude circle grows. The tiny stray kitten's line lands soft and true
— even the Grumblers pause. Miss and Walker exchange a look.

One grumbled,
"My rock is smooth."
Another muttered,
"My tail can groove."
A third one shrugged,
"My lunch had some crunch."

Then a small stray whispered,
"Somebody fed me today."

The whole block got quiet
in a different kind of way.

Good. Better. Best.

ILLUSTRATION — Rain starting; everyone under the porch together — accidentally cozy. A Grumbler confused by his own gratitude. Tyson unbothered, grinning.

The Grumblers tried
to stay salty and sour.
They lasted about
one half of an hour.

Then the bulldog mumbled,
"My paws are not wet."
Then paused.
"Wait. It's raining.
That's the best one yet."

They tried to bring me down.
But I'm built low and happy.
So that didn't work.
At ³¹all.

ILLUSTRATION — Quiet turning point. Tyson centered in warm light; the word TYSON shifts from gray to gold.

That's when I realized:

I didn't need to fight them.

I didn't need
to prove them wrong.

I didn't need
to change my name.

I needed to change
what my name meant.

ILLUSTRATION — Tyson walking tall down Barker Boulevard, Miss riding his back like a tiny captain. Gloom-bubbles slide right off his fur.

When they whispered,
"You can't,"
I answered,
"Yes, I can."

You threw your shade,
but I let it slide,
because I've got the sun
and a kitten with pride.

Your words can't stick.
My stride's too strong.
I'm walking my truth
and wagging along.

ILLUSTRATION — Miss's signature move — squaring up, weaving between Tyson's legs, fearless. Tyson gentle beside her, not scolding, just loving.

Miss stretched tall.
"My quiet place helped you.
I taught rather well."

"Yes, Miss. It's true.
But maybe that fearless
has a lesson for *you*.

You square up at big dogs.
You strut at the moon.
Brave is a gift —
but so is a friend
who knows when to listen."

"We'll see,"³⁴ she said.

ILLUSTRATION — Walker, Tyson, and Miss in a calm triangle of friendship under the big oak. Golden hour light.

Walker spoke low
from the shade of the oak.

"Truth without kindness
is not really love.
Courage is good.
And gentle is too.
The wise heart knows
which one to do."

ILLUSTRATION — Porch steps at sunset, thought-birds passing overhead without landing.
Tyson waves a paw at them, easy.

So I stayed Tyson,
but not quite the same.

I carried my past.
I reclaimed my name.

No longer just "trouble."
No longer stuck.

I still had hard thoughts.
They still flew by.
But now I could wave
and let them pass by.

ILLUSTRATION — Hero shot: neighborhood kids and animals gathered around Tyson.
Fence sign: TYSON'S YARD — ALL FRIENDS WELCOME. The Grumblers in line too, "just researching."

Now the same name
they flinched at before
is the name the whole block
comes looking for.

"Tyson! The gentle one!"
"Tyson! Our friend!"

Not because I changed it.
Because I **owned** it.

Not because they approved.
Because I stopped asking.

ILLUSTRATION — Tyson speaking directly to the reader, Miss on his head, Walker behind him. Bright, joyful block backdrop.

So if someone says,
"Tyson sounds tough,"

I just smile and say,

"I'm positively Tyson."

Because your choices
shape your fate...
not your name.

And the obstacle?
The obstacle is the way.

ILLUSTRATION — Full celebration: Tyson, Miss, Walker, the softened Grumble Pack, squirrels waving harmless YEAH! flags. Signs: Good, Better, Best · Who's Got It Worse? — Closed for Repairs.

Don't judge a friend
by their name or their bark.
Sometimes they need
a chance to leave a mark.

And when the Grumblers
try to pull you off course, remember:

Your choices determine the ship's course.

Stay steady. Seize the day.
Keep an even keel.
And always keep it real.

Tyson is the most misunderstood dog on the whole wide block.

The neighborhood hears his name and decides he must be trouble. Then the Grumble Pack joins the fray — spreading rumors, stirring the street, and pulling everyone into their favorite game: **Who's Got It Worse?**

But with help from Miss the Kitten and old Walker the Wise, Tyson learns that names do not steer dogs. **Choices do.**

Because your choices shape your fate, not your name.
And a good dog walks right through the blame.